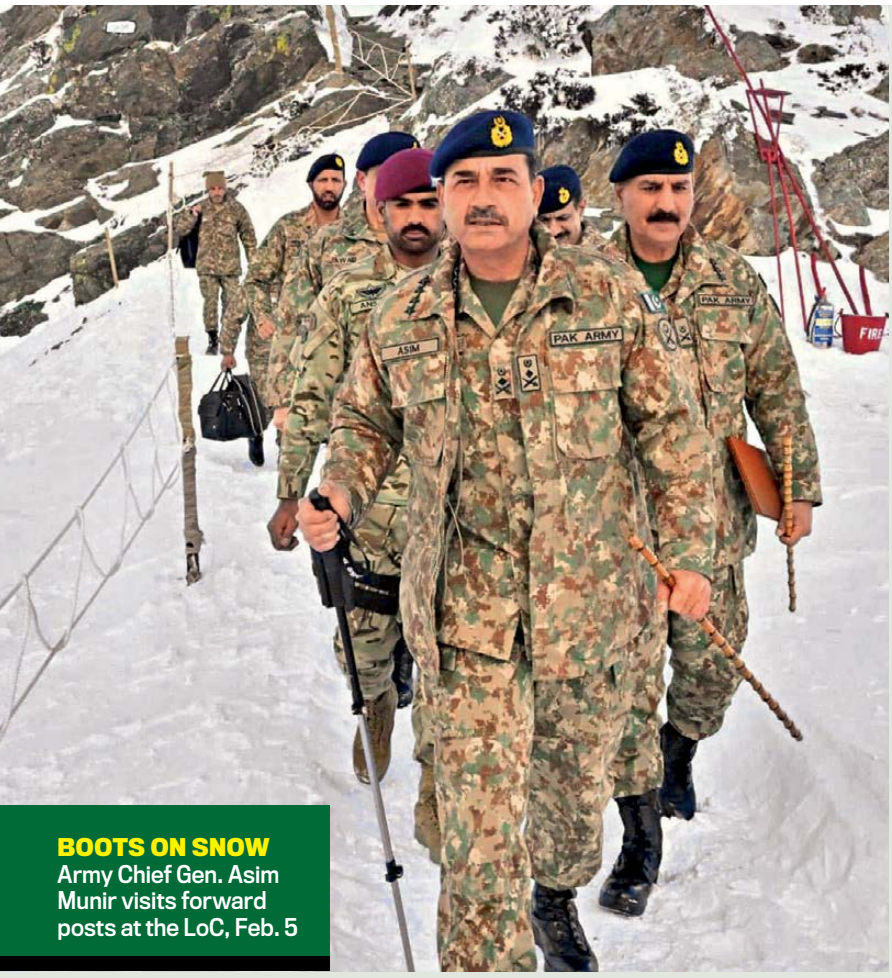


BOOTS ON SNOW
Army Chief Gen. Asim Munir visits forward posts at the LoC, Feb. 5

the Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) after only eight months in office, in 2019. The normal tenure for the ISI chief is three years. It is rumoured, though never confirmed, that problems arose because Gen. Munir had brought to Imran's attention issues of corruption within his close circles. He was replaced by Gen. Faiz as ISI chief.

A WIDELY EXPERIENCED OFFICER

Born in Rawalpindi, Gen. Munir is considered to be an outstanding officer. However, it is also true that he does not hail from the blue blood of army officers, the cohort who emerge from the long course at the PMA in Kakul, which all previous army chiefs have been through. Instead, he joined the military through the Officer's Training School in Mangla Cantt, where he received the prestigious 'Sword of Honour'.

He also does not hail from a military family background—his late father was a school teacher and the imam of a mosque—and his early schooling was at a religious seminary. He had memorised the Quran by the age of seven, which is why he is often referred to as Hafiz Sahib.

A close associate of Gen. Bajwa, he had served as an infantry brigadier under him, commanding troops in the Force Command Northern Areas, including at Siachen. He has also served as corps commander, Gujranwala, as well as the quartermaster general during his career. Perhaps, more interestingly, he is the first chief of the Pakistan army to have served as the head of both the Military Intelligence (MI) and the ISI.

SOURCES SAY THAT GEN. MUNIR IS CONVINCED THAT RIOTS BY PTI SUPPORTERS AFTER IMRAN WAS ARRESTED IN MAY 2023 WERE AN ATTEMPT TO IGNITE A MUTINY IN THE MILITARY

Following the violent clashes across Pakistan on May 9, 2023, after Imran's arrest from the premises of the Islamabad High Court, there was a nationwide crackdown on PTI supporters. Sources within the military claim that Gen. Munir is convinced that the riots were a planned attempt to ignite a mutiny within the armed forces. The military, therefore, has pushed to have the rioters tried in military courts, although this has received pushback from parts of civil society and the courts.

While Gen. Munir has steadfastly refused to be drawn in publicly on partisan politics and has expressed his resolve to see democracy prosper in the country, many in the PTI are convinced that their current tribulations will not ease as long as he is at the helm. Many of the party's supporters abroad continue to target him on social media. In the months ahead, given Pakistan's fragmented polity, Gen. Munir will have to balance out demands for the army to remain politically neutral, while ensuring the armed forces' sanguine belief that in its well-being lies Pakistan's salvation. ■

– Hasan Zaidi